

Retail and E-Commerce English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

Audience: retail managers, e-commerce teams, merchandising staff, store operations leaders, fulfillment teams, customer service managers, marketplace sellers, and growth operators

Focus: A retail and e-commerce English curriculum for merchandising, pricing, inventory, fulfillment, marketplaces, customer complaints, returns, conversion metrics, promotions, and vendor coordination.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Merchandising and Assortment Planning

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
assortment	In retail and e-commerce, assortment is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss assortment choices using customer, margin, and inventory language.	clarify assortment; document assortment	Contrast: assortment should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify assortment and the evidence that supports it.
SKU	In retail and e-commerce, SKU is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss assortment choices using customer, margin, and inventory language.	clarify SKU; document SKU	Contrast: SKU should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify SKU and the evidence that supports it.
sell-through	In retail and e-commerce, sell-through is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss assortment choices using customer, margin, and inventory language.	clarify sell-through; document sell-through	Contrast: sell-through should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify sell-through and the evidence that supports it.
gross margin	In retail and e-commerce, gross margin is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to discuss assortment choices using customer, margin, and inventory language.	track gross margin; explain a change in gross margin	Contrast: gross margin measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track gross margin by segment and explain what changed.

Pricing, Promotions, and Margin

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
markdown	In retail and e-commerce, markdown is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to explain discount strategy beyond top-line sales.	clarify markdown; document markdown	Contrast: markdown should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify markdown and the evidence that supports it.
promotion	In retail and e-commerce, promotion is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to explain discount strategy beyond top-line sales.	clarify promotion; document promotion	Contrast: promotion should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify promotion and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
gross margin	In retail and e-commerce, gross margin is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to explain discount strategy beyond top-line sales.	track gross margin; explain a change in gross margin	Contrast: gross margin measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track gross margin by segment and explain what changed.
cannibalization	In retail and e-commerce, cannibalization is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to explain discount strategy beyond top-line sales.	clarify cannibalization; document cannibalization	Contrast: cannibalization should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify cannibalization and the evidence that supports it.

Inventory, Allocation, and Replenishment

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
allocation	In retail and e-commerce, allocation is an operational constraint that affects how much work can be completed, by whom, and by when. Use it when teams need to balance stock availability with working capital.	clarify allocation; document allocation	Contrast: allocation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify allocation and the evidence that supports it.
replenishment	In retail and e-commerce, replenishment is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to balance stock availability with working capital.	clarify replenishment; document replenishment	Contrast: replenishment should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify replenishment and the evidence that supports it.
stockout	In retail and e-commerce, stockout is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to balance stock availability with working capital.	clarify stockout; document stockout	Contrast: stockout should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify stockout and the evidence that supports it.
inventory turn	In retail and e-commerce, inventory turn is an operational constraint that affects how much work can be completed, by whom, and by when. Use it when teams need to balance stock availability with working capital.	clarify inventory turn; document inventory turn	Contrast: inventory turn should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify inventory turn and the evidence that supports it.

Fulfillment, Shipping, and Returns

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
fulfillment	In retail and e-commerce, fulfillment is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate order problems with clear recovery options.	clarify fulfillment; document fulfillment	Contrast: fulfillment should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify fulfillment and the evidence that supports it.
SLA	Service-level agreement defining expected service performance or response commitments.	clarify SLA; document SLA	Contrast: SLA should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify SLA and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
return rate	In retail and e-commerce, return rate is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to communicate order problems with clear recovery options.	track return rate; explain a change in return rate	Contrast: return rate measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track return rate by segment and explain what changed.
carrier	In retail and e-commerce, carrier is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate order problems with clear recovery options.	clarify carrier; document carrier	Contrast: carrier should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify carrier and the evidence that supports it.

Conversion, UX, and Digital Analytics

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
conversion rate	In retail and e-commerce, conversion rate is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to discuss website performance using funnel language.	track conversion rate; explain a change in conversion rate	Contrast: conversion rate measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track conversion rate by segment and explain what changed.
funnel	In retail and e-commerce, funnel is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss website performance using funnel language.	clarify funnel; document funnel	Contrast: funnel should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify funnel and the evidence that supports it.
cart abandonment	In retail and e-commerce, cart abandonment is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss website performance using funnel language.	clarify cart abandonment; document cart abandonment	Contrast: cart abandonment should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify cart abandonment and the evidence that supports it.
A/B test	Controlled comparison of two variants to estimate the effect of a change on a defined outcome.	clarify A/B test; document A/B test	Contrast: A/B test should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify A/B test and the evidence that supports it.

Marketplace and Vendor Management

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
marketplace	In retail and e-commerce, marketplace is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to hold marketplace or vendor partners accountable.	clarify marketplace; document marketplace	Contrast: marketplace should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify marketplace and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
vendor scorecard	In retail and e-commerce, vendor scorecard is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to hold marketplace or vendor partners accountable.	track vendor scorecard; explain a change in vendor scorecard	Contrast: vendor scorecard measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track vendor scorecard by segment and explain what changed.
SLA	Service-level agreement defining expected service performance or response commitments.	clarify SLA; document SLA	Contrast: SLA should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify SLA and the evidence that supports it.
defect rate	In retail and e-commerce, defect rate is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to hold marketplace or vendor partners accountable.	track defect rate; explain a change in defect rate	Contrast: defect rate measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track defect rate by segment and explain what changed.

Customer Service and Escalations

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
return policy	In retail and e-commerce, return policy is an approved rule or decision framework that sets what is permitted, required, or acceptable. Use it when teams need to respond to angry customers without policy chaos.	apply the return policy; comply with the return policy	Contrast: return policy is an approved rule or threshold, not an informal preference. Example: Please confirm which return policy applies before we commit the team.
goodwill credit	In retail and e-commerce, goodwill credit is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to respond to angry customers without policy chaos.	clarify goodwill credit; document goodwill credit	Contrast: goodwill credit should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify goodwill credit and the evidence that supports it.
chargeback	In retail and e-commerce, chargeback is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to respond to angry customers without policy chaos.	clarify chargeback; document chargeback	Contrast: chargeback should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify chargeback and the evidence that supports it.
customer lifetime value	In retail and e-commerce, customer lifetime value is a stakeholder category whose needs, eligibility, experience, or obligations affect the decision. Use it when teams need to respond to angry customers without policy chaos.	clarify customer lifetime value; document customer lifetime value	Contrast: customer lifetime value should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify customer lifetime value and the evidence that supports it.

Store Operations and Omnichannel Execution

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
BOPIS	In retail and e-commerce, BOPIS is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to coordinate store, online, and fulfillment workflows.	clarify BOPIS; document BOPIS	Contrast: BOPIS should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify BOPIS and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
inventory accuracy	In retail and e-commerce, inventory accuracy is an operational constraint that affects how much work can be completed, by whom, and by when. Use it when teams need to coordinate store, online, and fulfillment workflows.	clarify inventory accuracy; document inventory accuracy	Contrast: inventory accuracy should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify inventory accuracy and the evidence that supports it.
queue	In retail and e-commerce, queue is an operational constraint that affects how much work can be completed, by whom, and by when. Use it when teams need to coordinate store, online, and fulfillment workflows.	clarify queue; document queue	Contrast: queue should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify queue and the evidence that supports it.
labor model	In retail and e-commerce, labor model is a defined information asset or analytical construct used to measure, explain, or predict an outcome. Use it when teams need to coordinate store, online, and fulfillment workflows.	clarify labor model; document labor model	Contrast: labor model should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify labor model and the evidence that supports it.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Merchandising and Assortment Planning	Before we commit, I want to confirm assortment, SKU, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If shelf space, demand signal, margin, inventory risk, and vendor capacity need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Pricing, Promotions, and Margin	Before we commit, I want to confirm markdown, promotion, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If gross margin, cannibalization, inventory, customer acquisition, and brand impact matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Inventory, Allocation, and Replenishment	Before we commit, I want to confirm allocation, replenishment, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If allocation, demand, lead time, logistics cost, and service level require planning., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Fulfillment, Shipping, and Returns	Before we commit, I want to confirm fulfillment, SLA, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If order status, carrier capacity, customer promise, refund policy, and service recovery matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Conversion, UX, and Digital Analytics	Before we commit, I want to confirm conversion rate, funnel, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If instrumentation, device mix, payment errors, and funnel step drop-off need analysis., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Marketplace and Vendor Management	Before we commit, I want to confirm marketplace, vendor scorecard, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scorecards, sla, customer impact, inventory, and remediation plan need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Customer Service and Escalations	Before we commit, I want to confirm return policy, goodwill credit, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If policy, goodwill, fraud risk, and customer lifetime value need balanced judgment., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Store Operations and Omnichannel Execution	Before we commit, I want to confirm BOPIS, inventory accuracy, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If labor, inventory accuracy, queue management, and customer expectations all matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.

- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Contrast Pairs

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
assortment vs gross margin	In merchandising and assortment planning, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
markdown vs cannibalization	In pricing, promotions, and margin, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
allocation vs inventory turn	In inventory, allocation, and replenishment, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
fulfillment vs carrier	In fulfillment, shipping, and returns, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
conversion rate vs A/B test	In conversion, ux, and digital analytics, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
marketplace vs defect rate	In marketplace and vendor management, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
return policy vs customer lifetime value	In customer service and escalations, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
BOPIS vs labor model	In store operations and omnichannel execution, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.